On November 30, 1948, a fellow student, Burnett Pitt, received his Ph.D. We were friends, but rather cool ones. He was short, dark, sardonic, and rather close-mouthed. I didn't think he liked me, though that may just have been my misinterpretation of his way of talking.

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During World War II I had loved the comic strip "Barnaby" and was devastated when the cartoonist Crockett Johnson grew tired of it and stopped. Johnson had all kinds of clever touches that amused us all. When Atlas the Mental Giant couldn't remember O'Malley's name until he worked out a determinant on the slide rule he always carried with him, Meisel informed us delightedly that when the determinant was worked out, the answer was really O'Malley.

I didn't think I would ever enjoy a comic strip as much as I had that one, but in 1948, Walt Kelly came out with 'Togo" and it was a case of love at first sight. I actually began to cut out the strips, paste them in a book, and save them. Later on, of course, Pogo books came out with the individual strips collected and I no longer had to save my own. I just bought the books. ("Barnaby" strips had come out in two books of their own, which I bought and still possess.)

21

On December 4, 1948, there was a very pleasant Hydra Club meeting at Fletcher Pratt's place. He had started with three marmosets and now had fifteen and the place smelled terrible as a result. He offered us a marmoset, but though it looked very cute (not very different from Fletcher, in fact) we refused with a shudder.

Fred Pohl was there. He had now married for a third time—to Judy Merril.

Also present was Fredric Brown, a short, thin fellow who looked like a bookkeeper but who wrote excellent science-fiction short-shorts and amazingly good tough-guy detective novels. His book Screaming Mimi is a classic and my personal favorite of the things he wrote. He was a chess buff and wanted badly to play me, even though I told him

it was almost impossible for me to win a game against anyone. I had visited his apartment one time not long thereafter and he beat me rapidly in two games.